

Maslow's Vision for a Psychology of the Peace Table

Mike Sosteric

Nov 10, 2025

[url]

For those of you who don't know, psychologist Abraham Maslow was an intellectual and theoretical giant. He was the founding father of not one but two powerful new branches of Western Psychology, **Humanistic Psychology and Transpersonal Psychology**. And that's not all. He put into place theoretical and empirical foundations that he hoped would provide the path forward to a third new psychology, and advanced utopian psychology, a **Eupsychian Psychology**, aimed at creating the "good society", a society capable of creating happy, healthy, autonomous, and advanced human beings. A society capable of actuating full **Human Potential** and engaging full **Human Flourishing**.

Surprising?

Not really.

Maslow wasn't the first founding father to try and push the world in a Utopian direction. August Comte, evangelist of empirical verification and founding father of Sociology, set out an entirely new **Religion of Humanity, a universal religion** which he hoped would bring unity and shared purpose to humanity (Comte 1852).

Ambitious?

Definitely so.

All Maslow had to work with at the time was Freudian and Behavioural psychology. These were useless for what he wanted to do. He had to build an entire supporting framework; and he did, leap-frogging over extant theories. The scope of his achievement is mindboggling.

Visionary?

Quite so.

I mean, it all started with an actual vision he experienced driving home one day. As he later recalled:

One day just after Pearl Harbor, I was driving home and my car was stopped by a poor, pathetic parade. Boy Scouts and fat people and old uniforms and a flag and someone

playing a flute off-key. As I watched, the tears began to run down my face. I felt we didn't understand—not Hitler, nor the Germans, nor Stalin, nor the Communists. We didn't understand any of them. I felt that if we could understand, then we could make progress. **I had a vision of a peace table**, with people sitting around it, talking about human nature and hatred and war and peace and brotherhood... That moment changed my whole life." (As quoted in Hoffman 1999:148–49: emphasis added)

Witnessing a small, somewhat disheveled parade in the immediate wake of the attack on , he was suddenly struck by an overwhelming sense not of patriotism or vengeance, but of sorrow and clarity.

As Maslow himself admits, this visionary experience changed his life. It redirected his work. He went from talking about dominance, sex, and motivation in apes to setting down a theory of human needs that would become the root of a groundbreaking **Eupsychian Psychology** aimed at creating the conditions for the health and happiness of the entire human species (Maslow 1961a). Not to put too fine a point on it, rather than contributing to the machinery of war, he committed himself to developing what he called a "psychology for the peace table," a psychology rooted not in pathology (Freudianism), control (Behaviourism), and adjustment to a highly toxic society (Maslow 1961b), but in understanding the human so as to facilitate healing and full actualization of not only the individual self, but of the entire species.

Amazing, his ambition.

Maslow would spend the rest of his career attempting to build that psychology, and his contributions, as noted, were massive. He helped found the *Journal of Humanistic Psychology* in 1961 to serve as a platform for exploring these alternative, growth-oriented views of human nature (Bugental 1964) . He helped found the *Journal of Transpersonal Psychology* in 1969, to explore the “Farthest Reaches of Human Nature” (Maslow, A. H. 1969) i.e., the spiritual, mystical, and transcendent dimensions of the human experience . The culmination of these efforts was the nascent emergence of a Eupsychian Psychology, a psychology that would not only help resacralize an arid and dehumanized science (Maslow 1966; Sutich 1961, 1976), but would also specify exactly how to grow healthy, strong, whole, autonomous, fully functioning human beings. Not only that, it would be grounded in a **Eupsychian Theory** that would contribute, according to Maslow, to a reconceptualization of “every area of human knowledge: e.g., economics, sociology, biology, and every profession: e.g., the family, education, religion, etc.” (Maslow 1970:x) and provide new systems of meaning where religion has so thoroughly failed (Maslow 1964)

Stunning, the amount of work he was able to accomplish without a personal computer.

Maslow was explicit about his goals (Maslow 1968b) and active in developing curriculum (Maslow 1968a). He was also clear that the work that had been done as of 1970 was only the “bare beginning” (Maslow 1970:xxi), nevertheless progress had been made. In 1969 he writes that, “There is now available a new conception, of a higher possibility, of the healthy society. There are tools now available to judge and compare societies. One society can be judged to be better than another society, or healthier or possessing more ‘growth-fostering-potential.’ We can talk about the value of the society, or the function of the society—that is, the greatest coming to fulfillment of the people in the society” (Maslow, A. H. 1969:7).

Tragically, Maslow's vision was never fully realized. He died prematurely in 1970, at the age of 62. But more than that, as (Elkins 2009) documents, the broader humanistic project that Maslow helped inaugurate was aggressively marginalized and systematically defunded. Humanistic psychology, with its emancipatory, truth-seeking, and growth-affirming impulses, posed a threat to dominant ideological orders, and was therefore effectively “murdered,” its remnants today little more than a caricature of its former glory

Despite this, the seeds of Maslow's peace psychology continue to germinate. As crises mount and the inadequacies of our existing systems become clearer, the need for a Eupsychian turn—a return to needs-based, truth-centered, human development frameworks—is more urgent than ever.

References

- Bugental, J. F. T. (1964). The third force in psychology. *Journal of Humanistic Psychology*, 4(1), 19-26. <https://doi.org/10.1177/002216786400400102>
- Elkins, D. N. (2009). The medical model in psychotherapy: Its limitations and failures. *Journal of Humanistic Psychology*, 49(1), 66–84. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0022167808323005>
- Hoffman, E. (1988). *The right to be human: A biography of Abraham Maslow*. Los Angeles, CA: Jeremy P. Tarcher.
- Maslow, A. H. (1968). *The farther reaches of human nature*. New York: Viking Press.
- Sosteric, M. (2021). *Lightning Path Workbook Two: The HEALING Framework*. Lightning Path Press.
- Sutich, A. J. (1969). The emergence of the transpersonal orientation: A personal account. *Journal of Transpersonal Psychology*, 1(1), 5–19.

